Leguminous plants have symbiotic relation with the *Rhizobium* bacteria found in the root nodules of these plants. These plants have the ability to fix atmospheric nitrogen in their roots with the help of these bacteria. The fruits of this plant are called legumes. Examples of legumes include alfalfa, clover, peas, beans, lentils, lupins, mesquite, carob, soy, and peanuts. These plants are used in crop rotation to multiply soil nitrogen.

21.4 Seed Bank

Seed bank is a place where seeds are stored in order to preserve genetic diversity. Seeds may be viable for hundreds and even thousands of years. Seed banks are like seed libraries that contain valuable information about evolution strategies of plants.

The Royal Botanical Gardens located in Kolkatta first started collecting seeds formally as seed bank. Seed banks were created to store native varieties of seeds. With this initiative farmers have started preserving indigenous seeds and reducing their dependence on hybrid seeds from seed companies. The simple and healthiest method of seed storage is in the air tight earthen pots. Navadanya Seed Bank, a nongovernmental organization located in New Delhi conserve around 50,000 crop varieties, with the primary focus on preservation of grain species.



Figure 21.18 Navadanya Seed Bank

Acharya Jagadish Chandra Bose Indian Botanic Garden located in Kolkatta was earlier called Royal Botanic Garden. This garden exhibits a wide variety of rare plants and a total collection of over 12,000 specimens. The area of this garden spreads over 109 hectares.

21.4.1 Seed balls

Seed balls are a mixture of soil, compost and plant seeds. These balls are thrown into land areas. With the monsoon set in, these planted seed balls will germinate into seedling. Making seed ball is a step towards conserving the natural ecosystems.

Seed balls are prepared by non-government organization and enthusiastic school children to grow tree for ecosystem restoration. The concept of seed ball has potential to increase tree cover and also to improve the awareness among the people about conserving plants.

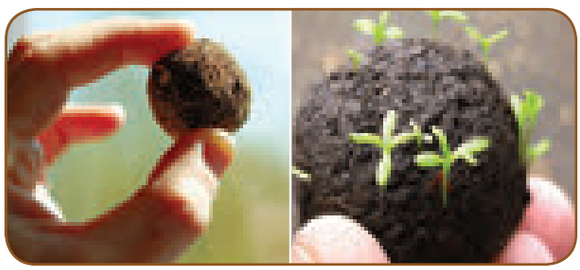


Figure 21.19 Seed ball

Activity 5

Take some seeds of the fruits you eat and mix it with compost. Add some clay with them and roll them into small balls. Allow them to dry under the sun for two or three days. Take these balls and drop them in dry and arid areas. This will help new plants to grow. You can throw those balls while you are travelling. This will help grow plants in areas where there is no plant cover.

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